

Introduction to Modern Job Evaluation

A practical guide to how contemporary job evaluation works, why traditional systems often struggle, and what organisations should look for in a more sustainable framework.

IN THIS GUIDE YOU WILL EXPLORE

- ✓ The role versus person distinction
- ✓ What makes a framework credible
- ✓ Why transparency matters
- ✓ How modern organisations think differently about grading

01 Introduction

Many organisations still use job evaluation methods that were designed for a more stable world — one with slower organisational change, more fixed role boundaries, and heavier reliance on detailed job descriptions. Those approaches can still work in some environments.

But in many modern organisations, they begin to struggle over time. Roles evolve faster than documentation. Structures become more fluid. Specialist, managerial, commercial, and project-based roles become harder to compare through older grading logic. And many traditional methods become increasingly dependent on indirect interpretation, specialist evaluators, and processes that are difficult for the wider organisation to understand or maintain.

Engage was built to respond to those realities.

It is a modern factor-based job evaluation methodology that allows organisations to evaluate roles through five structured judgment grids, with a stronger emphasis on direct role knowledge, transparency of logic, speed of use, and internal ownership over time. The purpose of this comparison is not to suggest that all traditional methods are wrong. It is to show where Engage differs — and why some organisations find it more practical, credible, and sustainable in modern settings.

SIDE-BY-SIDE COMPARISON

Dimension	Traditional job evaluation approaches	Engage
Starting point	Often rely heavily on job descriptions and indirect documentation about the role	Can use role descriptions as reference, but does not require them; direct role knowledge is central
Type of methodology	Usually structured, but often experienced as specialist-heavy and process-intensive	Modern factor-based methodology using five evaluation grids and structured judgment
Role knowledge in the room	Direct knowledge is often limited or excluded, with committees relying on second-hand information	Encourages evaluation in groups of knowledgeable people, including incumbents or informed representatives
Speed of use	Can be slow, time-intensive, and highly bureaucratic	Designed to be fast and practical — “5 judgments, 5 minutes” as a working principle
Ease of explanation	Logic can be hard for non-specialists to follow and defend internally	Transparent, visible, and easier to explain because judgments are made openly and practically
Transparency	Often perceived as a closed or black-box process	Built for an open, dialogue-based process with nothing hidden from participants
Dependency on consultants	Often highly dependent on external or specialist evaluators	Designed to build internal ownership and capability over time
Suitability for fluid roles	Can struggle where roles evolve quickly or structures are flexible	Specifically suited to flexible roles, fluid structures, and quick resizing
Maintenance over time	Often hard to maintain once the original project is complete	Easier to maintain internally because the methodology is simpler, faster, and more transparent
Use of job descriptions	Often central to the process	Useful, but not critical; Engage is built to work without complete job profiles if needed
Evaluation style	Can feel abstract or detached from operational reality	More practical and applied, using structured judgments based on real role context
Process style	Often specialist-led, technical, and formal	Inclusive, active, open, and suitable for broader organisational participation
Trust and credibility	Can weaken if the organisation does not understand how outcomes were reached	Increases trust because reasoning is more visible and easier to follow
Technology support	Often process-led with less flexible real-time support	Supported by web and Excel functionality for live evaluation and updating
Output flexibility	May tie the organisation more tightly to one grading system or platform	Results can be converted into the client’s grading platform of choice, including internal systems, IPE, Hay, Patterson, TASK, and others

02 The role of job descriptions

One of the biggest differences between Engage and many traditional approaches is the role of the job description. Traditional methods often place the job description at the centre of the evaluation. Engage treats it differently.

A job description can be helpful as a reference point, but it is not the foundation of the method. That matters because job descriptions are often incomplete, outdated, or influenced by the person who wrote them. In fast-changing organisations, they can lag behind the reality of the role very quickly. Engage is designed to reduce over-dependence on the document and increase reliance on informed role knowledge and structured judgment.

03 Direct knowledge versus indirect interpretation

Traditional methodologies often evaluate roles through indirect information. That can create risk: the role may be misunderstood, the description may be biased, the committee may not fully understand the real work, and the outcome may overstate or understate the actual size of the role.

Engage is designed to bring more direct knowledge into the room. This improves practical understanding, quality of judgment, speed of clarification, and trust in the result. That does not mean the process becomes informal. It means it becomes more grounded in reality.

04 What makes a methodology easier to maintain?

A methodology is easier to maintain when it is understandable, transparent, fast enough to use, trusted by the organisation, not overly dependent on external specialists, and practical in environments where roles change regularly. This is where Engage is intentionally different.

It is designed not only to produce grades, but to support internal ownership, ongoing resizing, committee use, transparent review, and easier future application. That makes it particularly useful in organisations that want job evaluation to become a living governance process, not just a one-time technical exercise.

05 A simple summary

Traditional methods often work best in more stable, document-heavy environments. Engage is better suited to organisations that need a more practical approach, faster application, stronger transparency, easier explanation, and greater internal sustainability. Traditional approaches often prioritise formality and documentation; Engage prioritises practical role understanding, transparency, and usability.

See how Engage compares in practice

Book a working session and experience the methodology using your own roles — we'll grade up to 10 live, so you can see the method, the logic, and the outcomes in action.

[Book a demo →](#)

Engage Job Evaluation is a methodology of Africa People Advisory Group (APAG). · engage.africapeopleadvisory.com